India – Size and Location

The big idea

India is a large country lying entirely in the **Northern Hemisphere**, at the head of the Indian Ocean. Its size, its position between East and West Asia and its long coastline have shaped its climate, trade, culture and history.

INDIA'S NUMBERS

Latitudinal extent: 8°4'N to 37°6'N · **Longitudinal extent:** 68°7'E to 97°25'E · **Area:** 3.28 million sq km (about **2.4%** of the world's land area) · **7th largest** country in the world · **Land boundary:** about **15,200 km** · **Coastline** (mainland plus islands): **7,516.6 km** · **Standard Meridian: 82°30'E**, passing through **Mirzapur** (Uttar Pradesh).

Location and size

The mainland of India extends between **8°4'N and 37°6'N** latitudes and **68°7'E and 97°25'E** longitudes. The **Tropic of Cancer (23°30'N)** divides the country into almost two equal parts. To the south-east and south-west of the mainland lie the **Andaman and Nicobar Islands** (Bay of Bengal) and the **Lakshadweep Islands** (Arabian Sea).

The **southernmost point** of the Indian Union is **Indira Point** (6°45'N) in the Great Nicobar Island; it got submerged under seawater in the **2004 tsunami**. The southernmost point of the mainland is **Kanyakumari**.

Size: India is the seventh largest country after Russia, Canada, USA, China, Brazil and Australia. The Himalayas lie in the north-west, north and north-east; south of about 22°N latitude India tapers and extends into the Indian Ocean, dividing it into the **Arabian Sea** (west) and the **Bay of Bengal** (east).

East–west and north–south extent: both are about **30 degrees**, yet the actual **north–south distance (about 3,214 km)** is greater than the east–west distance (about **2,933 km**). This is because the distance between longitudes decreases towards the poles, while the distance between latitudes stays the same.

Time difference: From **Gujarat** (west) to **Arunachal Pradesh** (east) there is a time lag of about **two hours** (30° × 4 minutes = 120 minutes). So India accepts the time along **82°30'E** as its **Indian Standard Time (IST)**. Latitude also matters: the duration of day and night varies more as we move from south to north (Kanyakumari has nearly equal day and night; Kashmir has big variations).

WHY IS 82°30'E CHOSEN?

It lies roughly in the middle of India's longitudinal extent (68°7'E to 97°25'E), and it is a multiple of 7°30' (time zones are set at 7.5° intervals = 30 minutes). IST is 5 hours 30 minutes ahead of GMT.

India and the world

- India lies centrally between **East and West Asia**, a southward extension of the Asian continent.
- The **trans-Indian Ocean routes** connecting Europe in the west and East Asia pass through India. The **Deccan Peninsula** protrudes into the Indian Ocean, helping India keep close contact with West Asia, Africa and Europe on the western coast and South-east and East Asia on the eastern coast.
- **No other country has a long coastline on the Indian Ocean as India**, and the ocean is named after India.
- Since the opening of the **Suez Canal in 1869**, India's distance from Europe has been reduced by **7,000 km**.
- India's contacts with the world are very old: ideas of the **Upanishads and the Ramayana**, the stories of the **Panchtantra**, **Indian numerals and the decimal system** reached many parts of the world. Spices and muslin were exported. In

turn, Greek sculpture and the architecture of domes and minarets from West Asia came to India.

- The land routes, through mountain **passes** in the north (Khyber, Bolan, Shipkila, Nathula and others), have been used by travellers since ancient times.

India's neighbours

India has **28 states and 8 Union Territories**. India shares land boundaries with:

- **Pakistan** and **Afghanistan** in the north-west,
- **China (Tibet), Nepal and Bhutan** in the north,
- **Myanmar** and **Bangladesh** in the east.

Southern neighbours across the sea are the island countries **Sri Lanka** and **Maldives**. **Sri Lanka** is separated from India by a narrow channel formed by the **Palk Strait** and the **Gulf of Mannar**. **Maldives** lies to the south of the Lakshadweep Islands.

MAP POINTS TO PRACTISE

Tropic of Cancer, Standard Meridian (82°30'E), Indira Point, Kanyakumari, Palk Strait, Gulf of Mannar, Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Lakshadweep, and the states touching the Tropic of Cancer: **Gujarat, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, West Bengal, Tripura and Mizoram** (8 states).

SAME DEGREES, DIFFERENT DISTANCE

Students often say "both extents are 30°, so distances are equal". Wrong: north–south distance is greater because longitudes converge towards the poles.

BOARD FAVOURITE

"Why is the difference between the duration of day and night hardly felt at Kanyakumari but not so in Kashmir?" Answer: Kanyakumari is close to the Equator, where day and night are nearly equal all year; Kashmir is farther north, so the length of day and night changes much more with the seasons.

Quick recap

- India lies wholly in the Northern Hemisphere, 8°4'N–37°6'N and 68°7'E–97°25'E.
- Area 3.28 million sq km, 2.4% of world area, 7th largest.
- Tropic of Cancer divides India into two nearly equal halves; IST meridian 82°30'E (Mirzapur).
- Central location on Indian Ocean routes; Suez Canal (1869) cut distance to Europe by 7,000 km.
- Neighbours: Pakistan, Afghanistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Myanmar, Bangladesh; Sri Lanka and Maldives across the sea.

Practice questions

1. Which latitude divides India into almost two equal parts?
   (a) Equator (b) Tropic of Cancer (c) Tropic of Capricorn (d) Arctic Circle
2. India's Standard Meridian is
   (a) 68°7'E (b) 97°25'E (c) 23°30'E (d) 82°30'E
3. What percentage of the world's total geographical area does India account for?
   (a) 1.2% (b) 2.4% (c) 4.2% (d) 17%
4. Sri Lanka is separated from India by
   (a) the Ten Degree Channel and the Bay of Bengal (b) the Strait of Malacca (c) the Palk Strait and the Gulf of Mannar (d) the Arabian Sea
5. The southernmost point of the Indian Union is
   (a) Indira Point (b) Kanyakumari (c) Rameswaram (d) Kavaratti
6. The opening of the Suez Canal in 1869 reduced India's distance from Europe by about
   (a) 2,000 km (b) 3,214 km (c) 15,200 km (d) 7,000 km
7. Which of these countries does NOT share a land boundary with India?
   (a) Bhutan (b) Myanmar (c) Sri Lanka (d) Afghanistan
8. Why is 82°30'E selected as the Standard Meridian of India?
9. Explain how India's location has helped it in establishing contacts with the world.

Answers: 1. b 2. d 3. b 4. c 5. a 6. d 7. c 8. see notes 9. see notes